

SOPHOCLES
TRACHINIAE

[Women of Trachis]

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TRANSLATOR'S NOTE

In the following text, the line number without brackets refer to the English translation; those in square brackets refer to the Greek text. In the English text, short indented lines have been included with short lines above them in computing the appropriate line number. The stage directions and footnotes have been provided by the translator.

In this translation, possessives of words ending in -s are usually indicated in the common way (that is, by adding -'s (e.g. *Zeus* and *Zeus's*). This convention adds a syllable to the spoken word (the sound -iz). Sometimes, for metrical reasons, this English text indicates such possession in an alternate manner, with a simple apostrophe. This form of the possessive does not add an extra syllable to the spoken name (e.g., *Hercules* and *Hercules'* are both three-syllable words; whereas, *Hercules's* has four syllables).

The translator would like to acknowledge the valuable assistance of Richard Jebb's commentary and translation (available online at Perseus).

A NOTE ON THE MYTHOLOGICAL BACKGROUND

Like almost all Greek legends, the Herakles (Hercules) story has many versions (especially since Herakles was a very popular figure in Greek drama and poetry). The following brief account summarizes some details of the traditional story (for a full discussion of the various traditional stories about Herakles, consult Jebb's excellent discussion in his commentary).

Herakles was a son of Zeus, born to a mortal mother, Alcmene. His mortal father was Amphitryon. Both parents were from Argos, but they had to leave Argos before the birth, and thus Herakles was born in Thebes. Goddess Hera, a constant enemy of Herakles, tried

WOMEN OF TRACHIS

to kill him in his crib by sending two snakes, but baby Herakles strangled them both. Later, when Herakles was a young man, Hera drove him mad, and he killed his own children (from his wife Megara; in some accounts, he killed Megara as well). As a result of this crime, Herakles had to work for his cousin Eurystheus, king of Mycenae, and perform the famous twelve labours of Herakles (killing the Nemean lion, killing the Lernaean Hydra, capturing the Ceryneian hind, capturing the Erymanthian boar, cleaning the Augean stables, killing the Stymphalian birds, capturing the Cretan bull, stealing the mares of Diomedes, obtaining the belt of Hippolyta, seizing the cattle of Geryon, stealing the golden apples of the Hesperides, and capturing Cerberus, the three-headed hound guarding the gates of Hades). When Herakles had completed these tasks, Hera again struck him with a fit of madness, and he killed Iphitos, a prince of Oechalia. To atone for this murder, Herakles had to sell himself into bondage to Omphale, a queen of Lydia (in Asia Minor).

Sophocles ignores the story of Herakles's wife Megara and the slaughtered children in order to have Deianeira and Herakles marry well before the twelve labours for Eurystheus. During these labours, Deianeira and their children live in Tiryns. Some time after he completes those labours, Herakles visits king Eurytus in Oechalia and asks him if he can have Iole, the king's daughter, as his concubine. The king refuses and mocks Herakles. Later in Tiryns, Herakles kills Iphitos, Eurytus's son (Sophocles makes no mention of a fit of madness sent by Hera), and as a result, Herakles and Deianeira have to leave Tiryns and move to Trachis. Herakles also has to atone for the murder of Iphitos by serving Omphale. He spends a year working for the Lydian queen, and then sets off to conquer Eurytus by attacking the city of Oechalia. Once he has killed Eurytus and sacked the city, he begins his return journey to Trachis, sending captive Iole on ahead of him. At this point, the action of the play begins.

Other necessary details will be provided in the footnotes.

WOMEN OF TRACHIS

TRACHINIAE

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

DEIANEIRA, wife of Herakles

NURSE

HYLLUS, son of Herakles and Deianeira

MESSENGER

LICHAS, a herald, one of Herakles's servants

HERAKLES

OLD MAN

CHORUS: A group of Trachinian women.¹

*[The play takes place in Trachis in front of the home of Herakles. Deianeira enters from the house accompanied by the Nurse.]*²

DEIANEIRA

Men have a saying established long ago:
no one can judge the life of any mortal
as good or bad until that man is dead.
But in my case, though I have not yet reached
the land of Hades, I know all too well
how miserable and difficult life is.
When I was with Oeneus, my father,
and still lived at home with him in Pleuron,
I had the most painful fear of marriage,
more than any young girl in Aetolia.
For I had a suitor, Achelöus,
the river god, who in three different shapes
kept on asking for me from my father.³
Once he arrived in the body of a bull,
then as a serpent with glittering coils,
then as a man with an ox's forehead
and streams of fountain water pouring down
his bearded face. Yes, that was my suitor.
When I expected him, I always prayed,
in my unhappiness, that I would die
before I'd ever come into his bed.
But then, later on, to my great delight,

10

[10]

20

¹Note that the speeches assigned to the Chorus include those spoken by the Chorus Leader, by part of the Chorus, by a single member of the Chorus, and by all of the Chorus, as a director of a production will determine.

²Trachis is a town just north of Delphi, near Thermopylae. It was renamed Heraklea Trachinia in 426 BC.

³Achelöus is pronounced as four syllables: Ach-el-o-us, hence the dieresis over the o.

the celebrated son of Zeus arrived,
 Alcmene's child. He fought Achelöus [20]
 and set me free. I cannot clearly say
 what happened in that struggle. I don't know.
 No one does. Someone who was not afraid
 to watch them could perhaps describe it.⁴
 I just sat there, overwhelmed with terror,
 afraid my beauty would, before the end, 30
 bring me grief. But finally warrior Zeus
 made sure it ended well, if it is true
 that the result was good. For even though
 I am the chosen wife of Herakles,
 I still nourish fear after fear for him,
 and each night brings me new anxiety,
 which the next night's worries drive away. [30]
 We have children, but he only sees them
 from time to time, like a tenant farmer
 who only visits his distant grain fields 40
 when he sows the crop and at the harvest.
 He'd come home and then leave us once again—
 that's what life was like while he was slaving
 for that man who kept sending him away.⁵
 Now he has completed all those labours,
 but at this point I am even more afraid.
 For since he killed the mighty Iphitos,
 we have been driven into exile here,
 in Trachis, living in a stranger's home, [40]
 and no one knows where Herakles has gone.⁶ 50
 With him not here, the only thing I know
 is bitter pain. It's clear he must have had
 a nasty accident, for since he left
 many months have passed—fifteen already—
 and still no word. Something bad has happened.
 The written tablets he left here with me
 warned me of it. How often I have prayed
 to the gods they would not bring me sorrow!

⁴The Chorus offers some details of the fight between Achelöus and Herakles below at 622 ff. The Roman poet Ovid provides a long account of the struggle (as described by Achelöus) in *Metamorphoses* (Book 9, lines 1 ff.).

⁵The phrase "that man" is a reference to Eurystheus, for whom Herakles had to perform the twelve labours.

⁶The stranger who has provided a home for Herakles and his family is, according to the traditional stories, Ceÿx, the king of Trachis (Jebb).

NURSE

Mistress Deianeira—I have seen you
 shedding tears so often, in your sadness, 60 [50]
 as you grieve the absence of great Herakles.
 But this time, if it is appropriate
 for a slave's opinions to provide advice
 to those who are born free, then my duty
 is to state what you should do. You have sons—
 many of them—and yet you do not send
 any of them off to find your husband.
 Hyllus would be especially suitable,
 if he cares about his father and believes
 we all should know that he is doing well. 70
 Here he comes now, hurrying to the house—
 he's in a rush. So if what I advise
 seems reasonable, then the time is right
 to act on what I urge—use Hyllus now. [60]

[Enter Hyllus, moving quickly towards the palace.]

DEIANEIRA

Ah, my son, my child, judicious words may fall
 from humble servants—like this woman here.
 She is a slave, but what she says is true.

HYLLUS

What does she say, mother? If it's something
 you can speak to me about, then tell me.

DEIANEIRA

She says that since your father has been gone 80
 for such a long time, it is scandalous
 you have not gone to find out where he is.

HYLLUS

But I do know where he is, if a rumour
 I have heard is a story I can trust.

DEIANEIRA

My child, what have you heard? Where has he been?

HYLLUS

They say he has spent a long time working—
 an entire year—as a hired servant,

in bondage to a Lydian woman.⁷

[70]

DEIANEIRA

Well, if it's true he has put up with that,
then nothing will surprise me anymore.

90

HYLLUS

But now, according to what I have heard,
he is finished with that task.

DEIANEIRA

Where is he then?
From those reports, is he alive or dead?

HYLLUS

They say he has set off to fight a war—
or is about to—against Euboea,
a territory ruled by Eurytus.⁸

DEIANEIRA

My son, are you aware that Herakles
left some trustworthy oracles with me
about that very place?

HYLLUS

No, I didn't know.
What kind of oracles?

DEIANEIRA

They prophesy
that in this expedition his life will end,
or else when it is over he will live
all his remaining days in peace and quiet.
My child, his fate is on the balance scale.
Will you not help? If Herakles survives,
then so do we—if not we die with him.

100

[80]

⁷The Lydian woman is Omphale, queen of Lydia (in Asia Minor). To atone for the murder of Iphitos, the Delphic Oracle decreed that Herakles had to work for her as hired help for a period of one year, a doubly shameful task for Herakles, because Omphale was a woman and because she was a barbarian (i.e., not Greek).

⁸Euboea is a long and narrow island very close to the east coast of the Greek mainland.

HYLLUS

Mother, I will go. Had I been informed
 about oracles proclaiming things like this,
 I would have left here a long time ago.
 As things stood, my father's usual fortunes 110
 never roused concerns or serious worry.
 But now I understand why you're so troubled,
 I will not stop until I have discovered [90]
 the truth about what's really going on.

DEIANEIRA

Leave now, my son. The news he's doing well—
 even if it's late—will be a fine reward.

[Hyllus leaves. Enter the Chorus of Women of Trachis.]

CHORUS

O Sun, offspring born from mother Night,
 as the glittering stars are stripped away
 from the one who lulls you once again to sleep
 in a blaze of fire, O Sun, I beg you— 120
 reveal to me where Herakles has gone!
 O shining god with your fiery light,
 where is Alcmene's son? Is he at sea, [100]
 or now on one of the twin continents?⁹
 O you, whose eye is mightiest of all,
 speak to me! For Deianeira here—
 a prize for whom men fought—is grieving,
 her spirit, like the mourning nightingale,
 always yearning. The sadness never ends.
 Her tearful eyes can never ease their sorrow, 130
 as she recalls with fear her husband's journey.
 Worn down with torments on a widow's bed, [110]
 in wretched desolation she expects
 nothing but disaster. Just as one sees
 tireless winds from north or south driving
 row after row of waves that rise and fall
 across the boundless sea, so the strains of life,
 as wild as the seas of Crete, whirl him round,

⁹Jebb notes that the phrase "twin continents" refers to Europe and Asia (with Africa included in the latter) and that expression means, in effect, "in the habitable world."

that son of Cadmus, and raise him once again.¹⁰
 And yet some god is always there to help
 and keep him far away from Hades' home.

140 [120]

[Turning towards Deianeira.]

With all respect we must take issue with you
 and counsel you against such desperate grief.
 We say it is not right to wear away
 your finer hopes. For the son of Cronos,
 the ruler who accomplishes all things,
 does not allot a painless life to men.
 Sorrow and joy revolve for everyone,
 just like the constellation of the Bear,
 whose stars keep moving round in circles.
 The glittering magnificence of Night
 does not remain in place for mortal beings,
 and nor do wealth and sorrow—each of these
 can in an instant disappear, and then
 great happiness or pain returns once more.
 My queen, I'm urging you to let these things
 revive your hopes, for who has ever known
 Zeus to show no care for his own children?

150 [130]

DEIANEIRA

What you have said shows me you understand
 that I am suffering. But at your age
 you are so innocent. Ah, how I pray
 you never learn the life-destroying pain
 I feel. Young growing life is nourished
 in sheltered regions of its own, undisturbed
 by storms, or winds, or Sun god's scorching heat.
 It lives with joy, free from toil and torment,
 until the virgin girl becomes a wife
 and bears her share of troubles in the night,
 fearing for her husband and her children.
 In such a situation, any woman

160
 [150]
 170

¹⁰Herakles was not literally a "son of Cadmus" or linked to the founder of Thebes in any blood relationship. Herakles' family came from Argos. However, as a result of a family quarrel between Herakles's mortal father, Amphitryon, and his uncle Electryon, in which the latter was killed, the family moved to Thebes, where Herakles was born. Also, as Jebb notes, youthful Herakles "had been adopted into the 'Cadmean' nobility of Thebes."

might sense the agonies that weigh me down
 by looking at her own experience
 and understand why so many sorrows
 have made me weep. But there is one worry
 greater than before that I must speak of.
 When, on his latest journey, lord Herakles
 set out from home, he left here in the house
 an ancient tablet inscribed with symbols.
 He'd never thought of mentioning it before
 when he was setting out on some adventure, 180
 one of his many labours. He always left
 full of confidence that he would triumph,
 not like a man about to meet his death. [160]
 But this time, as if he was going to die,
 he told me what to take as my inheritance
 and what shares he had assigned the children
 of their father's land. And he set a date
 for the division—he insisted that,
 once a year and three months had elapsed
 after his departure, he was destined 190
 either to perish then and there, or else,
 if he escaped the danger at that time,
 his life thereafter would be trouble free.
 He said that was the fate set by the gods
 to bring an end to Herakles's toils. [170]
 He added he had heard the very same
 from the ancient oak tree at Dodona
 which spoke out through the two priestesses there.¹¹
 And now the time has come when the truth
 the oracle foretold will be revealed 200
 and what it said will be fulfilled. That is why
 my fears have roused me from a gentle sleep.
 I'm terrified, my friends, I'll be a widow,
 forced to live without the finest of all men.

CHORUS

You should not speak now. Someone is coming—
 I see a man wearing a laurel crown,
 a sign he brings good news.

[Enter the MESSENGER, an old man.]

¹¹At Zeus's Oracle at Dodoma, prophetic signs were taken from the rustling leaves in an ancient oak tree. These were then interpreted by two priestesses called the Peleiades.

MESSENGER

Queen Deianeira, [180]

I will be the first messenger with news
to alleviate your fears. I can report
that Alcmene's son lives—he has triumphed
and is now bringing home fresh spoils of war
in honour of our native country's gods. 210

DEIANEIRA

What are you telling me, old man?

MESSENGER

Your husband,

whom so many people hold in high esteem,
will soon be coming back—he will be here,
celebrating his victorious triumph.

DEIANEIRA

Who told you this? Was it a citizen
or some foreigner?

MESSENGER

The herald Lichas

has announced the news to many people
in a summer pasture where cattle graze. 220
I heard it from him, and I rushed away,
so I could be the very first to tell you
and benefit from doing you a favour. [190]

DEIANEIRA

If he has good news, why is he not here?

MESSENGER

Lady, he can hardly move. The Malians
have him surrounded, a whole crowd of them,
standing in a circle asking questions.
He cannot get away. They're all eager
to hear him tell them what they wish to know
and won't let Lichas leave until he does. 230
So he's being held up there against his will,
because that's what those Malians demand.

But soon you will see him arrive in person.¹²

DEIANEIRA

O Zeus, ruler of the uncut meadows, [200]
lands of Oeta consecrated to you,
you bring us joy after all these years!
Raise your voices, you women in the house
and those outside the hall—now we can reap
the bliss of the bright dawn this message brings,
a happiness beyond my fondest hopes. 240

CHORUS

Let those who are about to be new brides
sing out with joyous shouts for hearth and home,
and let the cries of men arise in unison
for archer god Apollo, our defender!
You young girls chant a hymn of grateful praise. [210]
Cry out to his sister, the deer hunter,
Ortygian Artemis, goddess holding high
a torch in either hand, and to the nymphs,
our neighbours in this land. I am raised up
and spurn no more the music of the flute. 250
O tyrant of my heart! And this ivy—
see how its leaves excite me! Evoe!
It whirls me swiftly in the Bacchic dance!
O Paean! Paean!¹³ [220]

[The Chorus dances in joyful celebration. They stop suddenly as the Chorus leader sees Lichas approaching.]

CHORUS

Look there, dear lady!
You can witness the good news as it unfolds
before your very eyes!

DEIANEIRA

My dear companions,

¹²The Malian Gulf was about six miles from Trachis.

¹³Ortygia was an island where Apollo and Artemis were born to their mother Leto (their father was Zeus). The music of the flute (the “tyrant of my heart”) was associated with ecstatic religious worship, especially in the rituals of the god Dionysus (as was ivy, his sacred plant). “Evoe” is an ecstatic cry associated with the worship of Dionysus. The ivy is probably worn by members of the chorus in their hair. Bacchus is another name for Dionysus. Paean was the name of the Greek god of healing and is sometimes used (as here) in celebrations invoking Apollo.

my eyes are keen enough to notice things—
I see that group of people coming here.

[Enter Lichas and some captive girls, including Iole.]

DEIANEIRA *[addressing Lichas]*

Welcome, herald—a joyful welcome home
after your long absence—if you bring good news. 260

LICHAS

We are happy to be home, my lady,
and delighted with those words of welcome
appropriate to news of noble deeds. [230]
For when a man is truly fortunate
one's greeting should be kind and generous.

DEIANEIRA

Most welcome of friends, tell me first of all
what I most need to know. Can I expect
to see Herakles alive?

LICHAS

When I left,
he was alive and well—in excellent health,
with no sign of any serious illness. 270

DEIANEIRA

Where was he? In his ancestral lands
or some barbarian country? Tell me.

LICHAS

He was in Euboea—on a headland,
setting up altars and grounds of fruit trees
dedicated to the god Cenaean Zeus.¹⁴

DEIANEIRA

Is he striving to fulfil a promise
or did some oracle tell him to do it?

LICHAS

It was a vow he made when setting out
to ravage the country of these women— [240]

¹⁴Cenaeum was a headland in Euboea where there was a temple to Zeus.

the prisoners you see in front of you.

280

DEIANEIRA

These women—in the name of the gods,
who are they? And who do they belong to?
They deserve our pity, unless their plight
deceives me about what really happened.

LICHAS

They are your husband's captives. He chose them
as prizes for himself and for the gods,
once he had ransacked Eurytus's city.

DEIANEIRA

And it was for this city he stayed away
such an unimaginable length of time,
all those countless days?

LICHAS

No. Most of that time,

so he himself asserts, he was not free,
but was a slave sold into servitude
in Lydia. These words must not upset you,
my lady, for lord Zeus arranged it all.¹⁵ [250]
He says he spent a year in bondage there
toiling for Omphale, a barbarian.
He was so stung by this humiliation
he swore an oath that one day he would fight
the person who had brought about this shame
and force him, along with wife and children,
to live as slaves. And he kept that promise. 300
Once he had been purified, he gathered
a mercenary army and marched out
to overwhelm the land of Eurytus. [260]
Herakles claimed that of all living men
it was only Eurytus who had caused
the shame and suffering he had endured.¹⁶

¹⁵Zeus had ordered Hermes to take Herakles to Lydia and sell him to Omphale. This was a punishment for the murder of Iphitos. The humiliation of Herakles is obviously a potential source of shame for him and his family, but Lichas excuses his public recitation of the "shame" by informing Deianeira that Zeus is responsible for these events.

¹⁶Jebb notes that this notion of purification may simply refer to the year Herakles spent serving Omphale (the punishment imposed by Zeus for the killing of Iphitos) or it may also include a formal ritual purification at an appropriate place. Eurytus was king of Oechalia and the father of Iphitos. In some stories

He said he had once gone to Eurytus
 as an old comrade, visiting him at home,
 and Eurytus had verbally attacked him 310
 with many insults from a spiteful mind,
 alleging that in contests with the bow
 Herakles and his unerring arrows
 could never match the skill of his own sons.
 He sneered at Herakles, saying he'd sunk
 to being a free man's slave. Then one day
 at dinner, when Herakles was full of wine,
 they threw him out. Herakles was enraged.
 Sometime later, he noticed Iphitos [270]
 on the ridge at Tiryns following the trail 320
 of some stray horses that had wandered there—
 his eyes were searching for his animals,
 but his mind was elsewhere. So Herakles
 threw Iphitos from a towering summit.¹⁷
 Angry at this act, Olympian Zeus,
 father of all, would not condone it.
 He sent Herakles away to be sold
 in bondage, because on this occasion
 he had used deceit to murder someone.
 If he had avenged himself quite openly, 330
 Zeus surely would have pardoned Herakles
 and said his victory was just. Like us,
 the gods do not love reckless violence. [280]
 And so those people of Oechalia,
 who took such pride in saying evil things,
 are all inhabitants of Hades now.
 Their city is enslaved. These women you see,
 who had a happy life, have found a new one
 that no one envies—and so they come to you.
 Those were your husband's orders, and now I, 340
 his loyal servant, have carried them out.
 As for Herakles himself, you can be sure
 he will return, as soon as he has made
 a sacred offering to his father Zeus
 for conquering the city. This last news,

about Herakles, he was ordered as part of his purification to pay compensation to Eurytus for the death of Iphitos, but Herakles's offer was refused (another reason for his anger at Eurytus).

¹⁷Traditional stories indicate that Herakles threw Iphitos from the top of the walls of Tiryns. Many commentators prefer the notion that he threw his victim from a cliff up on the ridge. The Greek supports either notion. Jebb (in his commentary on this line) has a useful discussion of the options.

after all the good things I have told you,
will surely be the sweetest words by far. [290]

CHORUS

My lady, your happiness is now complete.
Some of it is present here before you,
and you have been informed about the rest. 350

DEIANEIRA

Yes, how could I not be fully justified
in feeling such delight when I hear news
my husband's mission has enjoyed success.
For my own happiness and his well being
are inseparably linked. Nonetheless,
for anyone with a judicious mind
there is in these events some room for fear:
a man who has done well may later fall.
My friends, a strange feeling of compassion
comes over me when I observe these girls, 360
poor, wretched exiles in a foreign land— [300]
homeless orphans, who at some point perhaps
were daughters of free men and who now
must spend their lives as slaves. O lord Zeus,
who shifts the tides of fortune in a war,
I pray I never see you act like this
against a child of mine, or if you do,
may I not be still alive to see it.
I feel such fear when I look at these girls.

[Deianeira singles out Iole and speaks directly to her.]

You poor unfortunate girl, who are you? 370
Are you unmarried? Do you have children?
Judging by your appearance, it would seem
you have no experience of such things.

[Deianeira turns to Lichas.]

Lichas, this girl here—who is her father? [310]
Tell me. Looking at her, I feel pity,
more so than I do for all the others—
she is the only one who understands
the dire situation she is facing.

LICHAS

How should I know? Why would you ask me?
She does not appear to be a daughter
of the humblest folk in Oechalia.

380

DEIANEIRA

Could she come from the ruling family?
Did Eurytus have any children?

LICHAS

I do not know. We did investigate,
but not in detail.

DEIANEIRA

What about her name?
Did you find that out from her companions?

LICHAS

No. When I was carrying out my work
I did not talk to them.

[Deianeira turns to speak to Iole.]

DEIANEIRA

Speak to me,
you poor girl, tell me yourself in your own words.
I find it troubling not knowing who you are.

390

LICHAS

If she keeps acting as she has before,
she'll hold her tongue. She has not said a thing
in all this time, not one word, great or small,
so heavy is the weight of her misfortune.
Ever since she left her windswept country,
not once has she stopped shedding tears of grief—
for her this situation is disastrous.
But we must make allowances for that.

DEIANEIRA

Then leave her alone, if that's what she wants.
Let's go in the palace. There is no need
for me to add more pain to the distress
she feels already. She's been through enough.
We'll all go in, so you may quickly leave

400 [330]

wherever you desire, and I can start
to organize arrangements in the house.

[Lichas and the captive girls move towards the palace. The Messenger detains Deianeira.]

MESSENGER

Before you go inside, stay here a moment,
so you may learn, without the others here,
just who those people are you're letting in.
You need to hear some things you have not heard,
facts I know about—with all the details.

410

DEIANEIRA

What are you saying? Why detain me here?

MESSENGER

Stay and listen. My earlier report—
you listened to that and it was useful.
I think what I say now will be the same.

[340]

DEIANEIRA

Shall I call the others to come back here?
Or do you wish to speak to me alone
before these women?

MESSENGER

To you and these women
I can speak freely. Let the others go.

DEIANEIRA

Well, they have left. Say what you have to say.

MESSENGER

Nothing Lichas said in his report just now
was true—either what he said then was false,
or else his earlier news was not the truth.

420

DEIANEIRA

What are you saying? Explain to me clearly
everything you know. What you just told me—
I don't know what that means.

[350]

MESSENGER

I heard Lichas state

in front of a whole crowd of witnesses
 that it was for this girl that Herakles
 conquered the high towers of Oechalia
 and slaughtered Eurytus. The only god
 who enticed him to that fight was Eros. 430
 It was not about Lydia at all,
 where he slaved in bondage to Omphale,
 or about killing Iphitos by hurling him
 down to his death. But Lichas now forgets
 to mention Eros and tells you something else.
 Herakles could not convince her father,
 who had conceived the girl, to offer him
 his daughter as a secret concubine, [360]
 so Herakles came up with a complaint,
 a trivial pretext, and launched a war 440
 against her native land, where Eurytus,
 as Lycus mentioned, was the reigning king.
 He killed Eurytus, the young girl's father,
 and sacked her city. Now, as you can see,
 on his way home he's sent her to this house.
 He has not arranged all that, my lady,
 for no reason or to make the girl a slave.
 You should not assume that's his intention.
 It's not likely, not if he is burning
 with a hidden passion. I thought it right 450
 to report all this to you, my lady,
 every detail I picked up from Lichas. [370]
 Many citizens of Trachis heard him speak,
 as I did, in the public gathering place.
 They can confirm this. If what I have said
 is unwelcome news, then I am sorry,
 but nonetheless my story is the truth.

DEIANEIRA

I feel so miserable. What do I do?
 What secret grief have I let in my home?
 This is disastrous for me! Lichas swore 460
 that this girl has no name. But is that true?

MESSENGER

No. Her name and parentage are famous.
 That girl is the daughter of Eurytus, [380]
 and people used to call her Iole.
 Lichas could not inform you of her birth

because, as he said, he did not enquire.

CHORUS

Let all other treacherous men be spared,
but may death and destruction strike
the man who forges devious secrets
by not being what he seems.

DEIANEIRA

O my friends, 470
what do I do? The words I have just heard
fill me with dread.

CHORUS

Go and question Lichas.
If you are willing to press him on this,
you might soon force him to reveal the truth.

DEIANEIRA

All right, I'll go. What you advise is good.

MESSENGER

Shall I wait for you here? What should I do? [390]

[Lichas appears, leaving the palace on his way to return to Herakles.]

DEIANEIRA

Stay here. Lichas is coming from the house
all on his own, without my summoning him.

LICHAS

I'm leaving, my lady, as you can see.
I'm off to rejoin Herakles. Tell me 480
what I should say to him.

DEIANEIRA

Your visit here
came very late, and now you hurry off
so soon, before we've had a chance to talk.

LICHAS

If there is anything you need to know,
I am here.

WOMEN OF TRACHIS

DEIANEIRA

Will you tell me the honest truth?

LICHAS

Yes, by great Zeus, I will—anything I know.

DEIANEIRA

Who is the woman you brought here with you? [400]

LICHAS

She is from Euboea. As for her parents,
I really cannot tell you.

MESSENGER

Look here, you!
Do you realize who you're talking to? 490

LICHAS

Who are you to ask me such a question?

MESSENGER

If you understand what I just asked you,
then be good enough to give us a reply.

LICHAS

I am speaking to lady Deianeira,
daughter of Oeneus, wife of Herakles,
and, unless my eyesight is deceiving me,
my royal mistress.

MESSENGER

That is precisely
what I wished to hear you say. Now, you claim
this lady is your mistress.

LICHAS

Yes, she is.

MESSENGER

All right then. In your view, what punishment
would you deserve if people now found out
that you were being dishonest with her? 500 [410]

LICHAS

How am I dishonest? And why on earth
are you making up such stories?

MESSENGER

I'm not—
it's you who's fabricating subtle lies.

LICHAS

I'm leaving. I was a fool to waste time
listening to you.

MESSENGER

No, you're not going,
not before you've answered one short question.

LICHAS

Speak, if you have to. You're hardly someone
who's about to hold his tongue.

MESSENGER

That captive girl—
the one you just escorted to the house—
you know the one I mean?

510

LICHAS

Yes, I know the one.
Why do you ask me that?

MESSENGER

Did you not claim
that this girl, whom you now say you don't know,
was Iole, daughter of Eurytas?

[420]

LICHAS

Who did I tell that? Who will step forward
and testify for you he heard me say it?
Where is he?

MESSENGER

You told a crowd of citizens
in that place where the Trachinians gather.
Lots of them heard you state her parentage
and her name.

520

LICHAS

People claim they heard me say that,
but stating what one feels is not the same
as offering an accurate report.

MESSENGER

What do you mean by “stating what one feels”?
When you spoke there, did you not give your oath
that you were bringing back this girl Iole
to be Herakles’ bride?

LICHAS

Me? His bride?
Dear lady, in the name of the gods, speak to me!
Tell me who this stranger is!

[430]

MESSENGER

I’m someone
who was in the audience when you said
Oechalia was completely overrun
thanks to Herakles’ passion. It was not
Lydian Omphale who destroyed it—
but his desire for the girl.

530

LICHAS

My lady,
send this man away. It is not prudent
to chatter with a person who’s deranged.

DEIANEIRA

In the name of Zeus, who hurls his lightning
down on the ridge-top forest lands of Oeta,
do not obscure the truth in your report!
You are not talking to an evil woman
or one who does not understand that men
are not by nature born to find delight
in the same place forever. So anyone
who, like a boxer, raises her two fists
in a fight with Eros is a thoughtless fool.
For Eros rules the gods as he desires—

540

[440]

and he rules me.¹⁸ Why not another woman,
 someone just like me? It would be madness
 for me to blame my husband or this girl
 if this disease now has him in its grip. 550
 She is his partner who shares in something
 that brings no shame on them, no wrong to me.
 That's not the point. But if you've learned to lie,
 if he has taught you that, then you have learned [450]
 an evil lesson. And if you taught yourself
 to act like this, you will appear deceitful
 when what you want is to be sympathetic.
 So do not lie. Tell me the truth—all of it.
 It is a fatal sickness for someone free
 to be called a liar. And if you hope 560
 you can still lie and get away with it,
 that will not happen, for many people
 listened to your speech, and they will tell me.
 If you are afraid, your fears are groundless,
 since what would hurt me more than anything
 is not to know the truth. What is so horrible
 about learning all the facts? Is it not true
 that Herakles has had all sorts of women— [460]
 and more of them than any other man?
 And yet I did not criticize or shame 570
 a single one of them.¹⁹ And I will not

¹⁸In Greek mythology Eros—the god of erotic passion—was one of the original gods, a son of Chaos. Later stories make him the son of Aphrodite, goddess of sexual love (in Roman mythology he becomes Cupid).

¹⁹The various women with whom Herakles had sons are listed by Apollodorus (2.7.8), as follows: “And he had sons by the daughters of Thespius, to wit: by Procris he had Antileon and Hippeus (for the eldest daughter bore twins); by Panope he had Threpsippas; by Lyse he had Eumedes; . . . he had Creon; by Epilais he had Astyanax; by Certhe he had Iobes; by Eurybia he had Polylaus; by Patro he had Archemachus; by Meline he had Laomedon; by Clytippe he had Eurycapys; by Eubote he had Eurypylus; by Aglaia he had Antiades; by Chryseis he had Onesippus; by Oriahe [he] had Leomenes; by Lysidice he had Teles; by Menippis he had Entelides; by Anthippe he had Hippodromus; by Eury . . . he had Teleutagoras; by Hippo he had Capylus; by Euboea he had Olympus; by Nice he had Nicodromus; by Argele he had Cleolaus; by Exole he had Erythras; by Xanthis he had Homolippus; by Stratonice he had Atromus; by Iphis he had Celeustanor; by Leothoe he had Antiphus; by Antiope he had Alopheus; by Calmetis he had Astybie; by Phyleis he had Tigasis; by Aeschreis he had Leuconies; by Anthea . . . ; by Eurypyle he had Archedicus; by Erato he had Dynastes; by Asopis he had Mentor; by Eone he had Smestrius; by Tiphys he had Lyncaeus; by Olympeusa he had Halocrates; by Heliconis he had Phalias; by Hesychia he had Oestrobles; by Terpsicrate he had Euryopes; by Elachia he had Buleus; by Nicippe he had Antimachus; by Pyrippehe [he] had Patroclus; by Praxithea he had Nephus; by Lysippe he had Erasippus; by Toxicrate he had Lycurgus; by Marse he had Bucolus; by Eurytele he had Leucippus; by Hippocrate he had Hippozygus. These he had by the daughters of Thespius. And he had sons of other women: by Deianira, daughter of Oeneus, he had Hyllus, Ctesippus, Glenus and Onites; by Megara, daughter of Creon, he had Terimachus, Deicoon, and Creontiades; by Omphale he had Agelalus, from whom the family of Croesus was descended, by Chalcioppe,

be any different now with Iole,
 not even if her passion makes her melt.
 When I looked at her I felt real pity,
 because her beauty has destroyed her life
 and because against her will the poor girl
 has ruined her country and enslaved it.
 But let the wind blow all these things away.
 As for you, you can tell your lies to others,
 but to me you must always speak the truth. 580

CHORUS

You should do what she says. It's good advice. [470]
 You'll have no grounds to blame her later on,
 and you will have our thanks.

LICHAS

Well then, dear lady,
 I see you think as mortal men should think
 and do not cloud your judgment. So I'll speak—
 I'll tell you the entire truth, hiding nothing.
 It is as this man says. Some time ago,
 a fearful passion for that girl pierced Herakles,
 and because of her he utterly destroyed
 her father's native country, Oechalia, 590
 and put it to the sword. But to his credit—
 I must add this—he never ordered me
 to hide the fact. Nor did he deny it. [480]
 It was me. I feared that telling you this news
 would pain your heart, and so I am at fault,
 if in your judgment I have been mistaken.
 But now you know the truth in every detail,
 so you should show compassion to this girl,
 both for his sake and for yours, and confirm
 those words you spoke just now. For with his hands 600
 Herakles may overpower all other things,
 but passion for this girl has conquered him.

DEIANEIRA

But that is how I do intend to act. [490]

daughter of Eurypyus, he had Thettalus; by Epicaste, daughter of Augeas, he had Thestalus; by Parthenope, daughter of Stymphalus, he had Everes; by Auge, daughter of Aleus, he had Telephus; by Astyoche, daughter of Phylas, he had Tlepolemus; by Astydamia, daughter of Amyntor, he had Ctesippus; by Autonoe, daughter of Pireus, he had Palaemon." (Translated by J. G. Frazier at <http://www.theoi.com/Text/Apollodorus2.html>).

I do not wish to lay upon myself
 the burden of a war against the gods.
 That would be futile. Let's go in the house,
 so you can carry back some words from me,
 and since one should acknowledge gifts received
 with one's own gifts, you can take these as well.
 You brought such fine things with you when you came, 610
 It is not right that you return with nothing,

[Deianeira and Lichas enter the palace.]

CHORUS

The glorious power of Aphrodite
 always triumphs! I will not now relate
 stories of the gods or speak about
 how she deceived lord Zeus, son of Cronos, [500]
 or his brothers Hades, lord of darkness,
 and lord Poseidon, shaker of the earth.²⁰
 But when Deianeira was to be a bride,
 what strong-armed men came to compete for her
 to be his wife? Who was prepared to step 620
 into that brutal battle in the dust?

One of them was mighty Achelöus
 who came to her as a four-legged bull
 with arching horns. He was a river god
 from Oeniadae. The other came from Thebes, [510]
 home of Bacchus, carrying a curved bow
 and brandishing his spears and cudgel.
 He was a son of Zeus. The two of them
 collided, each one eager for a bride,
 while Aphrodite, god of nuptial joy, 630
 sat in their midst as sole impartial judge.

Then all at once there was a thud of fists,
 the bow string quivered, the bull's horns rattled—
 and two men locking arms in grappling holds, [520]
 butting each other's heads with deadly blows,
 each man groaning from the strain. Meanwhile,

²⁰Zeus, Hades, and Poseidon were all sons of Cronos (and thus brothers). They drew lots to determine which parts of the earth each should rule. Zeus won the sky, Hades the underworld (hence, he is "lord of darkness"), and Poseidon the sea. Poseidon is called "shaker of the earth" because he is also god of earthquakes. Each of these major deities was at some point tricked by Aphrodite into one or more erotic entanglements.

the fair-eyed girl sat on a distant hill,
 waiting for the one she was to marry.
 The contest rages on, as I describe,
 while the bride these men are fighting for 640
 awaits the end in anguish. Once that came,
 like a lost calf, she had to leave her mother. [530]

[Deianeira enters from the palace. She is carrying a small chest.]

DEIANEIRA

My friends, our visitor inside my home
 is taking his leave of those captive girls,
 so I have slipped away, out of the house,
 to tell you of a plan I have in mind
 and to share with you the pain I suffer.
 For I have taken this young maiden in
 (who is, I think, no maiden any more)
 the way a man loads cargo on his ship, 650
 a freight that sets a load upon my heart.
 Now, under a single blanket, each of us
 will wait to be embraced in Herakles' arms. [540]
 That will be the reward I get from him,
 whom I have called a true and faithful man,
 for keeping his home going all these years.
 I cannot be angry with him—this illness
 has infected him so often—but then,
 to live together, share the house with her,
 the marriage, too. What woman could bear that? 660
 I see her youthful beauty ripening,
 while mine is in decline, and Herakles
 will turn his eye toward those blossoms
 he loves to pluck and turn away from me.
 That's why I am afraid that Herakles, [550]
 though he may still be called my husband,
 could well become the younger woman's man.
 But, as I said, getting angry makes no sense
 for any woman who can think things through.
 And so, my friends, I want to tell you this— 670
 I have a way to deal with all these fears
 and bring myself relief. Some time ago,
 an age-old monster once gave me a gift,
 which I keep in a bronze urn stashed away.
 I picked it up when I was still a girl
 from the blood of shaggy chested Nessus,

as he was dying. He was a centaur,
 who for a fee would hold men in his arms
 and take them through the raging waters
 of the Evenus, without oars or sails 680 [560]
 to help him ferry them across the stream.²¹
 He carried me, as well, up on his shoulders,
 when I was first a bride and my father
 had sent me off to follow Herakles.
 When we reached the middle of the river,
 Nessus' carnal hands began to grope me.
 I screamed, and in an instant Zeus's son
 turned round and shot a feathered arrow
 whistling through his chest, deep into his lungs.
 As he was dying, Nessus said these words: 690

"Daughter of old man Oeneus, listen. [570]
 If you follow what I say, then this trip
 will serve you well. You are the very last
 I will ever take across this river.
 With your own hands wipe up the clotted blood
 around my wound, where that monstrous creature,
 the Lernean Hydra, soaked the arrow
 in its black bile. With that you will possess
 a charm to win the heart of Herakles,
 so he will never look at any woman 700
 and love her more than he loves you."²²

My friends,
 I thought about this potion, which I kept,
 after Nessus died, locked away at home,
 and I have just now smeared this garment with it, [580]
 obeying everything that Nessus said
 while he was still alive. Now I've finished.

²¹A centaur was a legendary creature that was part man, part horse. This combination was usually imagined in one of two different ways: (1) a human torso (with arms) and head attached to the horse at the base of the horse's neck; (2) a human body (with legs) attached to the back two-thirds of a horse. Nessus appears here to be in the second group (according to Jebb, who calls the first group hippo-centaurs and the second group andro-centaurs). The Evenus was a river in western Greece, well-known for its dangerous current.

²²The Hydra was a terrifying monster with nine heads, living in Lerna. In his second labour, Herakles had to kill the beast. He attacked the heads, but every time he smashed one, two more would grow in its place, a process which Herakles dealt with by burning the creature's flesh as soon as he had demolished a head, thus preventing the emergence of more heads in that place. After he had killed the Hydra, Herakles dipped his arrows in its blood, in order to make them lethal. Nessus is urging Deianeira to collect the Hydra's venom which was on Herakles' arrow and which has now seeped into his blood around the wound.

I pray I'm never capable of acting
in vicious ways—I hope I never learn
such wicked things, for I hate those women
who dare to practise such malicious crimes. 710
But if this love potion somehow helps me
prevail against the girl and if its charms
do work on Herakles, then I am ready—
unless you think my plan is much too rash.
If that's the case, then I will end this.²³

CHORUS

No, no. If there's any reason to believe
this charm will work, as far as we're concerned
what you're proposing is not wrong at all.

DEIANEIRA

I have faith in it—it should be all right. [590]
But I can't be certain until I try. 720

CHORUS

To find that out you have to act. If not,
if you don't try, you never know for sure.

DEIANEIRA

We'll find out soon enough—I see the herald
already at the door. It won't be long
before he's on his way. But please make sure
this robe remains a closely guarded secret.
For if our shameful acts take place in darkness,
we will never fall and be dishonoured.

[Enter Lichas from the house.]

LICHAS

Tell me your instructions, child of Oeneus.
I have stayed here far too long already. 730

DEIANEIRA

While you've been inside talking to the women,
Lichas, I've been preparing something for you. [600]

²³Jebb points out (in his commentary on line 582) that the use of love potions was regarded suspiciously, since the results were often disastrous. Hence Deianeira's wish to reassure the Chorus of her intentions and to secure their approval.

Take this long woven robe—a gift I made
 with my own hands—to my absent husband.
 Give it to him, and tell him not to let
 any other person wear it before he does
 and not to expose it to the sunlight
 or to altar fires or a blazing hearth,
 until he stands there visible to all,
 displaying the robe in public to the gods, 740
 on a day when sacred bulls are slaughtered.
 For that is what I vowed: if I ever saw [610]
 or heard that he was safe and coming home,
 it was my duty to dress him in this robe
 and show him to the gods as a new man
 in fresh clothes offering them sacrifice.
 You will take the token stamped in this seal,
 which he will recognize quite easily.²⁴
 Now go. And, above all, follow the rule—
 messengers should never seek to carry out 750
 more than they are told—and then, beyond that,
 make sure you earn my thanks as well as his,
 and win yourself a double gratitude.

LICHAS

If as a messenger I have any skill [620]
 practising the art of herald Hermes,
 I will not fail to do what you have asked.
 I will take this casket and give it to him
 just as it is, and to this gift I will add
 assurances explaining why you sent it.

DEIANEIRA

You may leave now, for you have a good grasp 760
 of how things stand with us here in this house.

LICHAS

I understand. I'll tell him all is well.

DEIANEIRA

And you also know how I received her—
 that foreign girl—because you witnessed it.
 I welcomed her as if she were a friend.

²⁴The “token” Deianeira mentions is probably a wax seal on the box containing the robe Lichas is to take to Herakles. The imprint from her ring would be in the seal.

LICHAS

I did, and the sight struck my heart with joy.

DEIANEIRA

What else is there to tell? For I'm afraid [630]
it is too soon to speak of my desire,
until I know if he desires me too.

[Lichas leaves in a direction away from the house. Deianeira goes into the house.]

CHORUS

O you who live beside the thermal springs 770
between the harbour and the rocky cliffs
near Oeta's mountain and all those of you
along the Malian gulf's most inner shores
and headland rocks of holy Artemis,
the archer goddess with the golden bow,
there by the gateway of Thermopylae,
the famous meeting place of all the Greeks,
for you the lovely music of the flute [640]
will soon resound—not harsh or piercing notes,
but lyric melodies and sacred sounds.²⁵ 780
For Zeus's son—the child Alcmene bore—
is hurrying home and bringing with him
trophies his matchless excellence has won.
We thought he was completely lost to us
somewhere at sea. We waited twelve long months.
There was no news. Meanwhile his loving wife, [650]
her sad heart full of grief, always in tears,
kept yearning for him. Now angry Ares
has released her from her days of sorrow.²⁶
Let him come without delay. O let him come! 790
May the ship with many oars that carries him
keep sailing on until he reaches us,
leaving far behind the island altars,
where people say he offers sacrifice.
And from that place, I pray he reaches here [660]
filled with new desire for loving union,

²⁵Jebb points out that meetings of the Amphietyonic Council (a religious council made up of delegates from a number of independent Greek states) were held near Thermopylae.

²⁶This reference to Ares presumably means that by driving Herakles to war and victory, the god of war has freed him to come home and thus relieve Deianeira's worries.

won over by the charm rubbed in his robe.

[Deianeira enters from the house.]

DEIANEIRA

My friends, all those things I was just doing—
I'm afraid I've gone too far!

CHORUS

What's the matter,
Deianeira, daughter of Oeneus?

800

DEIANEIRA

I'm not sure. But I'm desperately worried.
Though I was hoping I would make things better,
I may have made a terrible mistake—
that's how it will look.

CHORUS

Is this about the gift,
that robe you sent to Herakles?

DEIANEIRA

Yes.
We should never urge people to act rashly
when we are not sure of what will happen.

[670]

CHORUS

If you can, tell us why you are afraid.

DEIANEIRA

My friends, I've just witnessed an amazing sight!
You will be dumbfounded when I tell you.
A white tuft of wool from a sheep's fleece,
the one I used just now to smear the potion
on the ceremonial robe, has vanished!
Nothing in the house made it disappear—
no, it devoured itself—it dissolved away
and crumbled into powder on a stone!
But for you to understand what happened,
I will have to give you all the details.
I was careful to carry out each step
the ferocious centaur whispered to me
as he lay dying from the arrow wound

810

[680]

820

deep in his side—they were etched in my mind,
 like words inscribed indelibly in bronze.
 I followed his instructions to the letter.
 I was to keep the ointment stored away,
 never near a fire or the sun's warm rays,
 until the time I wished to rub it on.
 That's what I did. A little while ago,
 when that moment came, I smeared the ointment
 on the robe. I did that inside the house, 830
 in secret. I used a piece of soft wool [690]
 pulled from one of our own sheep. After that,
 I folded up my present and placed it
 in that empty casket, out of the sun,
 as you all saw. But when I went back in,
 I noticed something I simply can't explain,
 a sight no human mind can comprehend.
 By chance I somehow threw that bit of wool
 I took to smear the robe into a place
 where it lay uncovered in the sunshine. 840
 As the tuft grew hot, it shrivelled away
 and crumbled into powder on the floor.
 It looked just like those particles of wood
 a saw produces as it cuts through timber. [700]
 It's still there, where it fell. And from that spot,
 from the earth where it now lies, clotted foam
 bubbles up, like the rich blue juice of grapes
 from vines of Bacchus poured out on the ground.
 Now I'm feeling dreadful. I have no idea
 how I sort this out. All I know is this— 850
 what I've done will end in a disaster.
 What reason did that monstrous centaur have?
 Why, as he lay dying, did he show me
 so much sympathy, when I was the one
 who brought about his death? No, that's not it.
 He was tricking me—he wanted to destroy
 the one whose weapon killed him. Now I see. [710]
 The knowledge comes too late. It cannot help.
 Unless I am quite wrong in what I think,
 then I alone—by some ill-fated chance— 860
 will be the one who utterly destroys him.
 I know the arrow that brought down Nessus
 could harm even a god, as it did Cheiron,

and slaughter any animal it touched.²⁷
 That same dark poisoned juice was in the blood
 oozing from the fatal wound in Nessus.
 How will it not kill Herakles as well?
 I think it must. But if he is to die,
 I am resolved that I will die with him
 and share the moment he is swept away.
 No noble woman who respects her birth
 can bear her life once she has been disgraced.

870 [720]

CHORUS

When dreadful things occur, we all must fear,
 but before we know how these events turn out,
 we must not give up hope.

DEIANEIRA

There is no hope,
 not when one makes such poorly thought-out plans.
 We have no reason to believe this will end well.

CHORUS

But men repress the anger in their hearts
 for those who make mistakes by accident.
 That's how things stand with you.

DEIANEIRA

No woman
 whose actions have ended in disaster
 would say those words—a woman who could
 has never known real sorrow in her home.

880

[730]

CHORUS

The best thing for you now is to keep quiet,
 unless you wish to talk to your own son.
 He left to find his father. Now he's back.

[Enter Hyllus.]

²⁷Cheiron (or Chiron), a son of Cronos (father of Zeus), was the most famous and respected of all centaurs. He was a friend of Herakles, but the latter shot him accidentally with a poisoned arrow. Cheiron was divine and could not die, but he could not be cured of the excessive pain caused by the wound. Eventually, in a bargain with Zeus, Cheiron gave up his immortality in exchange for the release of Prometheus (whom Zeus had chained a rock).

HYLLUS

Mother, as far as you're concerned, I wish
one of the following three things was true—
that you were dead, or, if you're still alive,
that you were mother to some other man,
or else that you could somehow trade that heart
you now possess for something better.

890

DEIANEIRA

What is it, my son? What could I have done
to make you hate me so?

HYLLUS

You want to know?
I'll tell you. Today you killed your husband—
my father!

[740]

DEIANEIRA

My son, what are you saying?

HYLLUS

I'm telling you the truth—what really happened.
No one can erase what he has witnessed.

DEIANEIRA

What do you mean, Hyllus? Who told you this?
Why do you charge me with this awful crime?

900

HYLLUS

I did not hear of it from someone else.
I saw my father's desperate agony
with my own eyes.

DEIANEIRA

Where did you find your father?
Where did you join him?

HYLLUS

If you have to know,
then I should tell you everything that happened.
Once Herakles had ravaged Oechalia,
Eurytus's splendid city, he left,
taking, as trophies of his victory,
the choicest spoils of war. In Euboea,

[750]

on Cape Ceneaeum, a promontory 910
 washed on both sides by the sea, he set up
 altars and groves sacred to father Zeus.
 That's where I first saw him. I was overjoyed.
 He was about to start a splendid sacrifice,
 when Lichas arrived, his personal herald,
 bringing with him that gift of yours from home,
 a deadly robe. My father put it on,
 as you instructed, and began the rite
 by offering up his finest plunder,
 twelve flawless bulls. Many different victims, 920 [760]
 a hundred sacrificial beasts in all,
 were led up to that altar. At the start,
 my poor ill-fated father was relaxed,
 as he prayed with a serene heart, happy
 to be wearing that ceremonial robe.
 But once the blood-red flames began to blaze
 above the sacred offerings and sizzling wood,
 his skin began to sweat, and the garment
 stuck against his sides, as if some craftsman
 had plastered it with glue to every joint. 930
 Spasms of biting pain attacked his bones,
 and then the poison, like lethal venom [770]
 from some vile snake, started to consume him.
 At that point he called for wretched Lichas,
 who was not in any way at all to blame
 for this evil act of yours, asking him
 what treasonous plot he was engaged in
 when he brought the robe. Poor hapless Lichas,
 quite ignorant of what was happening,
 told Herakles he had delivered your gift 940
 exactly as it was when he received it.
 When Herakles heard this, a piercing spasm
 attacked his lungs. He seized hold of Lichas
 by the ankle and threw him out to sea, [780]
 onto a surf-washed rock, smashing his skull
 to fragments, and the white stuff in his brain
 oozed out through his hair. When the gathered crowd
 saw my father in such a frantic state
 and Lichas lying dead, they howled with grief.
 No one wanted to get close to Herakles, 950
 for he was having a convulsive fit,
 rolling on the ground, leaping in the air,
 yelling and screaming, and all around him

the cries re-echoed from high mountain cliffs
in Locris and the headlands in Euboea.
When he grew weary from hurling himself
down on the earth over and over again [790]
in agony and from his howls of pain
he started cursing his ill-suited marriage
to a woman like you, a worthless wife, 960
a union encouraged by Oeneus,
where, by winning you, he ruined his life.
Then in the middle of the altar smoke
enveloping him, he raised his maddened eyes
and saw me in the crowd. I was weeping.
He stared at me and then cried out:

“My son,
come over here. Don’t run away from me
when I’m in trouble, even if that means
you have to die with me. Come, lift me up.
What matters now is to get me away 970
to a place no mortal man can see me. [800]
If you feel any sympathy at all,
at least take me as quickly as you can
to somewhere else, so I don’t die here.”

One he had given me these instructions,
we placed him on board ship and carried him
to Trachis, convulsed with pain and groaning.
It was an agonizing trip.²⁸ You’ll see him
soon enough—though I have no idea
if he is still alive or has just died. 980
And that, mother, is what makes you guilty—
the plans you made and later carried out
against my father. May avenging Justice
and the Furies see that you are punished!
I pray for that, if such a prayer is just.
It must be, for to me you have thrown aside [810]
all sense of what is right by murdering
the finest man of all those on this earth,
whose equal you will never see again.

²⁸Jebb notes that this journey would involve rowing the ship from Cape Ceneaeum to a harbour near Thermopylae (a distance of about 18 miles) and then a land trip (with the sailors carrying Herakles) of about six miles to Trachis.

[Deianeira moves silently towards the palace door.]

CHORUS *[to Deianeira as she is about to enter the house]*

You are leaving without saying a word? 990
 Surely you know that by staying silent
 you will be pleading your accuser's case?

[Deianeira goes into the palace.]

HYLLUS

Let her go. And let the fair winds blow her
 somewhere far away, where I no longer
 have to look at her. Why dignify her
 with the name of "mother"? What she has done
 reveals that she is nothing like a mother.
 Let her go. Good riddance! I hope she finds
 the happiness she has given my father. [820]

[Hyllus exits away from the palace.]

CHORUS

My friends, see how suddenly the words 1000
 uttered by that oracle so long ago
 reveal themselves to us—for they foretold
 that after all the months had passed that fill
 the time it takes to have twelve harvest seasons,
 the labours of the son of Zeus would end.
 And now those words are surely being fulfilled.
 For once a man no longer sees the light,
 how can he ever toil in slavery again? [830]

And if the centaur's murderous deceit
 infects his sides and he is now held tight 1010
 in a venomous net that sticks to him,
 whose poison Death itself engendered
 and a glittering serpent nursed, then how,
 when the fearful hydra has him in its grip,
 will he survive to see another sunrise?
 The treacherous words of black-haired Nessus
 prepared the fatal whips tormenting him,
 leaving him confused, writhing in pain,
 and his body blistering from poison. [840]

His poor wife did not foresee such evil. 1020

She only had a sense that his new marriage
 would quickly cause distress inside her home.
 And so she acted, following advice
 a stranger at that fatal meeting gave.
 Because of that she now groans in despair
 and sheds thick tears like softly falling dew.
 The coming doom brought on by that deceit [850]
 is heralding a catastrophic fall.

A river of our tears has broken out,
 as the poison spreads. Alas, this sickness 1030
 rouses our pity for splendid Herakles,
 more so than any other hardship
 his enemies have ever made him suffer.
 O you, the dark head of the battle spear
 fighting in the foremost ranks, how swiftly
 in earlier days your warlike spirit
 led your bride from Oechalia's heights!
 But Cyprian goddess Aphrodite,
 working in silence, has clearly been [860]
 the one who brought this to fruition. 1040

[There is a cry from within the palace.]

CHORUS MEMBER 1

Is my imagination tricking me,
 or did I just hear someone shouting out
 inside the house? What's going on in there?

CHORUS MEMBER 2

The sound was clear enough—a cry of grief.
 Some new calamity has struck this house.

[The Nurse comes through the doors of the palace.]

CHORUS MEMBER 3

The old woman is coming out to us.
 Look at that frown on her. She seems strange.
 She has some news for us.²⁹ [870]

²⁹The three short speeches by Chorus Members 1, 2, and 3 are sometimes combined into a single speech spoken by the Chorus Leader.

WOMEN OF TRACHIS

NURSE

O my children,
that gift has brought us nothing but disaster—
the one she sent to Herakles.

CHORUS

Tell us,
old woman. What's happened now?

1050

NURSE

She's gone.
Deianeira has left on her last journey,
without a single step away from home.

CHORUS

You mean to tell us she is dead?

NURSE

Yes.
That's what I said.

CHORUS

What? The lady's dead?

NURSE

I've already told you twice.

CHORUS

Poor doomed lady!
Can you tell us how she died?

NURSE

It was cruel—
the most pathetic way to die.

CHORUS

Tell us, woman.
Describe what happened.

NURSE

She took her life.

CHORUS

What passionate madness drove her to it,

1060

like the sharp point on a murderous spear?
One death after another—how could she
plan and carry this out all by herself?

NURSE

With a grim blow from an iron sword.

CHORUS

You poor fool! Did you see what happened?

NURSE

Yes, I saw. I was standing close to her.

CHORUS

What happened? How did she do it? Tell me.

[890]

NURSE

She chose to kill herself by her own hand.

CHORUS

What are you saying?

NURSE

I'm telling you the truth.

CHORUS

The new bride Iole has given birth—
she has delivered her first-born child,
a mighty spirit of vengeance in the house.

1070

NURSE

That's true. If you'd been there and witnessed
how she did it, you'd pity her much more.

CHORUS

And could a woman's hand dare such an act?

NURSE

Indeed it could—and it was horrible.
I'll describe it, and then you can confirm
if what I say is true. She was alone
when she came in the house and saw her son
getting a stretcher ready in the courtyard,
so he could go back and rejoin his father.

[900]

1080

She hid where no one else could see her,
 and lying down before the family altars,
 she moaned that they were being abandoned.
 When poor Deianeira touched anything
 familiar to her from habitual use,
 she wept, and, as she wandered aimlessly
 here and there throughout the house, if she glimpsed
 one of her cherished personal attendants,
 she cried aloud with sorrow at the sight, 1090
 lamenting her own fate and the future [910]
 of her children in a shattered household.³⁰
 Then she stopped, and I saw her suddenly
 rush in the bedroom where her husband sleeps.
 I hid where I could secretly observe her.
 I watched the woman spreading coverlets
 on Herakles' bed. Once she had finished,
 she climbed up on the bed and sat there,
 in the middle, burst into tears, and cried,

“Ah, my marriage bed and bridal chamber, 1100 [920]
 farewell—now and forever. Never again
 will you welcome me as Herakles' wife
 beneath these covers.”

After she said this, her hand
 with an urgent motion unpinned her dress
 where the brooch of beaten gold was fastened
 just above her breast. Then she uncovered
 her entire left side and arm. I ran off
 with all the strength I had and warned her son
 of what his mother was about to do.
 But by the time the two of us returned, 1110
 we found her dead. We saw that she had forced [930]
 a two-edged sword into her side and heart.
 Her son screamed out when he caught sight of her,
 for the poor lad realized his anger
 had driven her to it. He'd learned too late
 from servants in the house that what she did
 in carrying out what Nessus told her
 was done in ignorance. Hyllus collapsed,

³⁰The meaning of this line is obscure. The general sense is that the death of Herakles and the disgrace and death of Deianeira would destroy their family household, and all their property, including their servants, would be taken over by others.

stunned with grief. He could not stop weeping,
 moaning over her, covering her with kisses. 1120
 He lay down right beside her, whimpering
 he was the one who'd falsely charged her [940]
 with horrendous crimes. He was crying,
 because he would now become an orphan
 and have to live without her and his father.
 That's how this has ended. So any man
 who reckons on tomorrow or on days to come
 is foolish. For there is no tomorrow,
 until today has safely come and gone.

[Nurse exits into the house.]

CHORUS

Which calamity do I weep for first? 1130
 For which one do I feel more pity?
 I do not know, for all I feel is grief.
 The one death we have seen here in our home, [950]
 the other we are waiting for with dread.
 To see it and to wait feel much the same.
 O how I wish some strong and favouring wind
 might rise up in my home and carry me
 far from this place. Let me not die from fear [960]
 at the mere sight of Zeus's mighty son.
 For people say that he is coming home 1140
 in agony for which there is no cure—
 a fearful wonder no words can describe.

[A group carrying Herakles appears, moving slowly towards the house. The group is led by an Old Man.]

The man I was lamenting earlier,
 like a shrill nightingale, is drawing near
 in a strange looking group of foreigners.
 How are they carrying great Herakles?
 They are moving slowly and in silence,
 as if they are in mourning for a friend.
 They bear him here, and no one says a word.
 What should I think? Is he asleep or dead? 1150 [970]

[Hyllus enters from the house and moves up to meet the group carrying Herakles.]

HYLLUS

Alas, father, I feel so sad for you.
And what is to become of me?
What should I do?

OLD MAN [*pulling Hyllus aside*]

My child, do not talk to him,
in case you reawake the savage pain
that makes him furious. He is alive,
but only just. Bite your tongue in silence.

HYLLUS

What are you saying, old man? Is he alive?

OLD MAN

Do not wake him up when he is sleeping!
My boy, you'll just provoke his brutal illness,
which comes and goes. Do not bring it back!

1160 [980]

HYLLUS

But I find this suffering unbearable!
My heart's on fire!

HERAKLES [*waking up*]

O Zeus, what land is this?
Who are these people standing round me,
as I lie here in never-ending pain?
Aaaaaii, that hurts! The monster bites again!

OLD MAN

Did I not tell you it would be better
to stay silent? You've chased his sleep away!
His eyes and mind have woken up.

[990]

HYLLUS

I cannot stand it
when I see him tortured in this way.

HERAKLES

O Cenaea, where I built my altars,
have the offerings I made there earned
this harsh reward? O Zeus! In what torments
you have placed me, such agonizing pain.
In this miserable state, how I wish

1170

these eyes of mine had never seen you,
 had never sensed this flowering madness
 which no spell can relieve. What magician, [1000]
 what skillful healer, other than lord Zeus,
 can charm away this lethal pestilence?
 If only I could see someone like that, 1180
 and he could work some far-fetched miracle!

[Hyllus and the Old Man try to ease Herakles's pain by adjusting his position on the stretcher.]

O let me be! Leave me to my death pains!
 My final sleep! Why are you touching me?
 Where are you moving me? You're killing me!
 Just killing me! The pain was slumbering,
 and now you've woken it once more! Aaaaaiiii!
 It's seizing me and creeping up again! [1010]
 You men, you most unrighteous of all Greeks,
 where are you from? I spent a weary life
 in forests and at sea helping the Greeks 1190
 by ridding them of monsters, and now,
 when I'm in agony from this disease,
 will no one help me with his sword or fire?
 Aaaaaiiii! Is no one willing to come here
 and, with a single blow, slice off the head
 from this accursed body? Alas! Alas!

OLD MAN *[giving up trying to reposition Herakles]*
 Son of Herakles, I cannot manage this.
 I am not strong enough. You must shift him.
 You have more strength to help him than I do.

HYLLUS
 I'm holding him, but nothing I can do, 1200 [1020]
 with or without other people's help,
 will give me what I need to free his life
 from dreadful pain. Zeus has so decreed.

HERAKLES
 My boy, where are you? Come, grab hold of me
 and lift me up. Aaaaaiiii! Aaaaaiiii! O god!
 This savage illness is flaring up again—
 nothing anyone can do will stop it.
 It's leaping up and ripping me to pieces! [1030]

O Pallas, Pallas—I'm being tortured!³¹
 My boy, show your father some compassion. 1210
 Pull out that sword of yours and strike me here,
 under my collar bone. No one will blame you.
 Heal this pain, which your perfidious mother
 has used to drive me mad. I only hope
 I see her die like this—in the same way
 she's murdered me. O gentle Hades, [1040]
 brother of Zeus, let me rest and sleep.
 Let swift-winged death do away with me
 and bring my life of suffering to an end.

CHORUS

My friends, it makes me shudder when I hear 1220
 how much our lord is suffering. A man like him
 faced with such misfortune!

HERAKLES

My hands and shoulders
 have had to cope with many dangerous tasks,
 where pain was real, not some made-up story,
 but Zeus's wife and vicious Eurystheus
 never placed a grievous burden on me
 worse than the one now fastened to my back
 by that false-eyed girl, Oeneus' daughter, [1050]
 this clinging net woven by the Furies
 in which I'm dying. Pasted to my ribs, 1230
 it eats away my flesh, and settling down
 deep in my lungs it chokes my windpipe.
 It has already sucked my warm fresh blood
 and wasted my whole body, binding me
 in chains so harsh they cannot be described.
 No battle spearman, no armed companies
 of earth-born Giants, no savage creatures,
 no part of Greece or any foreign place, [1060]
 nor any of those lands I came to cleanse
 could ever do a thing like this to me.³² 1240
 But now a woman, a feeble woman,
 whose nature is not masculine at all,

³¹Pallas is a common name for the goddess Pallas Athena. Herakles was her half-brother. As Jebb notes, Athena is frequently depicted in art and story as a guardian and comforter of Herakles.

³²The Giants were monsters born from goddess Earth. When they sought to overthrow the Olympian gods in battle, Herakles fought on the side of the Olympians.

has overpowered me all by herself.
 She did not even use a sword! My boy,
 it's time you showed you are my true-born son,
 a child who does not hold your mother's name
 in greater honour than your father's. Bring her
 from the house—escort her personally—
 and hand her to me, so I can clearly see
 whether you grieve more to view my body 1250
 tortured in this way or to look at hers
 when she receives the punishment she's earned.
 Go now, my son. Be firm. And pity me. [1070]
 To many I've become an abject thing,
 moaning and weeping like a virgin girl,
 a sight no man has ever seen before.
 In earlier days, when I was in distress,
 I never cried, but in this wretched state
 I find I've now become a whining woman.
 Come here and stand beside your father. 1260
 See how much this poison makes me suffer.
 I'll take this covering off and show you.
 Look! Inspect this mutilated body—
 all of you! See how wretched I am now, [1080]
 how pitiful. Aaaaaiiii! I can't endure it!
 Another crippling spasm is scalding me,
 slicing through my ribs, and I must grapple
 with this ravenous pestilence once more,
 as it consumes me. O lord Hades, take me!
 O thunderbolt of Zeus, strike me! My lord, 1270
 my father, hurl down your fire on my head!
 Let lightning strike! This plague devours me.
 Its scorching flame has broken out again!
 O you hands of mine, you hands and shoulders,
 chest, and lovely arms. These are the same arms [1090]
 whose power overwhelmed that creature
 that terrorized all herdsmen in Nemea,
 a savage lion no man would approach
 or dare confront. You triumphed in that fight
 with the Lernaean Hydra and held off 1280
 that vicious, insolent, and lawless horde
 of wild beasts with a double form, who move
 like horses and whose strength is unsurpassed.
 You overcame the Erymanthian boar,
 captured the three-headed whelp of Hades,
 fierce Echidna's child, a monstrous hound

no man could defeat, and killed that serpent
in the remotest corner of the world [1100]
guarding the golden fruit.³³ I have endured
these hardships and a thousand other trials. 1290
No one has ever been declared the winner
in any fight against these hands of mine.
But now in this miserable condition,
my arms and legs have lost their strength,
and my body has been torn to pieces,
ravaged by destruction no one can see!
I, who, according to what people say,
was born from the very noblest mother.
I, who am called a son of starry Zeus.
But there is one thing you can be sure of— 1300
although I cannot move and may be nothing,
the woman who has brought all this about
will feel the strength I still have in my hands.
Just let her come out here. She'll soon learn [1110]
and let all people know that that in my death,
as in my life, I made the guilty pay.

CHORUS

Ah, poor Greece! I see so much misfortune
looming up for you, if you lose this man.

HYLLUS

Father, your pause now prompts me to speak up.

³³In the first of his famous twelve labours (set by Eurystheus) Herakles was sent to deal with a monstrous lion that was terrorizing a city in the Peloponnese. The animal's fur made it invulnerable to any weapon. Herakles knocked the animal out with his club and strangled it. Then he skinned the lion and from then on wore the lion's pelt as a garment (the skin retained its invulnerable qualities). Killing the Hydra, a water monster living in lake Lerna, was the second of Herakles' labours. The creature had numerous heads and, if one head was chopped off, two more would grow back in its place (see footnote 22 above). The wild beasts with a double form are centaurs (see footnote 21 above). Herakles had to fight a crowd of them when, while travelling to confront the Erymanthian boar, he visited the centaur Pholos. The centaurs were aroused by the smell of wine and attacked Herakles and Pholos. Herakles killed most of them. Herakles set out to capture the Erymanthian boar in his fourth labour; he tied the creature up and brought it back to Eurystheus. The "three-headed whelp of Hades" is Cerberus, a huge dog guarding the gates of the underworld, a child of the monster Echidna. In his final labour Herakles captured Cerberus and brought him back to Eurystheus, who was so terrified of the beast that he ordered Herakles to return it. In his eleventh labour, Herakles was charged with bringing back the famed golden apples in the Garden of the Hesperides located where the sun sets in the evening (i.e., in the far west). The apples were a divine gift and conferred immortality. To protect the fruit, Zeus's wife Hera had placed a serpent with a hundred heads (named Ladon) in the grove where the apples grew. Herakles killed the serpent.

Please listen to me, even though you're ill, 1310
 for I'm appealing to your sense of justice.
 Hear what I have to say. Do not react
 with that quick rage which gnaws upon your heart.
 If you grow too enraged, you'll never see
 that in this situation your resentment
 and the joy you seek taking your revenge
 are out of place.

HERAKLES

Say what it is you want 1120
 and then be quiet. I am far too sick
 to grasp what you are chattering about.

HYLLUS

I'm here to talk to you about my mother— 1320
 where she is now and how by accident
 she made a terrible mistake.

HERAKLES

You traitor!
 You mentioned her again and in my presence—
 that mother of yours who killed your father!

HYLLUS

Yes. What's happened makes it unacceptable
 for me to hold my tongue.

HERAKLES

To hold your tongue
 would be completely unacceptable,
 considering the evil she has done.

HYLLUS

Once you have learned what she has done today,
 you will not talk like that.

HERAKLES

Then speak up. 1330
 But be careful you do not betray me.

HYLLUS

I will speak. She is dead. She has just been killed. 1130

HERAKLES

Who killed her? That is astounding! But still,
it is not right that she was slain by someone else.

HYLLUS

She killed herself. There was no 'someone else.'

HERAKLES

Ah no! Before my hands could slaughter her,
as she deserves.

HYLLUS

If you heard her story,
that overwhelming rage you feel would change.

HERAKLES

A strange thing to say as you begin to speak!
Tell me what you mean.

HYLLUS

The truth is this—
she made a great mistake, but she meant well. 1340

HERAKLES

Traitor! She killed your father! Was that good?

HYLLUS

When she saw your new wife in her home,
she thought she ought to try to win you back
by applying a love charm. But she failed.

HERAKLES

And who in Trachis deals in charms like that? [1140]

HYLLUS

The centaur Nessus told her long ago
the potion would rekindle your desire.

HERAKLES

Ah, then this is the end. Alas for me,
a miserable wretch now at death's door. 1350
I can no longer see the light of day.
It is my time to die. At last I see
how matters stand with me. My son, go now—

for your father is no longer with you.
 Go summon your entire family here,
 including my poor mother, Alcmene,
 whose love affair with Zeus was all in vain,
 so all of you can hear before I die
 what I have learned from holy oracles. [1150]

HYLLUS

Your mother is not here. She moved away
 to Tiryns by the sea. Some of your children 1360
 have been taken there for her to raise,
 and others, you will learn, now live in Thebes.
 But those of us still here with you, father,
 will do what must be done, at your command.

HERAKLES

Then listen to the work you have to do.
 You are called my son, and the time has come
 for you to show the kind of man you are.
 Years ago my father made this prophecy—
 no creature still alive and breathing air 1370
 would ever kill me. No. My death would come [1160]
 from someone dead, already down in Hades.
 And now this savage centaur, although dead,
 has robbed me of my life, as Zeus foretold.
 I will explain to you how later oracles
 support the earlier one and thus confirm
 the ancient utterance. I wrote them down
 in the sacred precincts of the Selli,
 hill-dwellers who still sleep upon the ground.
 There my father's oak tree, which prophesies 1380
 through many different tongues, revealed to me
 that when the day arrived which has now come
 I would be released from all the labours [1170]
 life had laid upon me, and I believed
 this meant I would enjoy a peaceful life.³⁴
 But I can see it only meant that I would die,
 for the dead no longer face a life of toil.
 Now, my boy, since these words are coming true,
 you must be my ally and stand with me.

³⁴At Zeus's temple in Dodona, the rustling sounds in a sacred oak tree were interpreted by priestesses (see note 11 above). The Selli were a tribe living around Dodona. The comment about their sleeping on the ground is (according to Jebb) an indication that the Selli were a very old tribe with primitive customs.

Don't hesitate—you'll just provoke my rage. 1390
 Agree to work with me, like a good child
 who has discovered the most important rule—
 when fathers speak, their sons must all obey.

HYLLUS

Yes, father. At this point in our discussion,
 I have some serious concerns, but still,
 I will be guided by what you think best. [1180]

HERAKLES

Then to begin with, set your right hand in mine.

HYLLUS

Why? What promise do you want from me?
 What are you urging me to do?

HERAKLES

Give me your hand,
 and do not disobey.

HYLLUS

Here is my hand. 1400
 I will not deny you anything you ask.

HERAKLES

Now swear by the head of Zeus, my father.

HYLLUS

To do what? Can you tell me what it is?

HERAKLES

To carry out the task I will assign you.

HYLLUS

I swear it—may lord Zeus be my witness.

HERAKLES

Now pray that if you fail to keep this oath
 then you may suffer some calamity.

HYLLUS

That will not happen, since I'll keep my oath. [1190]
 But I will make that prayer.

HERAKLES

All right then.

You know the highest point on Oeta,
Zeus's sacred mountain? 1410

HYLLUS

I know it well.

I've often stood up there to sacrifice.

HERAKLES

With your own hands you must raise my body
and carry it up there, helped by your friends,
as many as you want. Once in that place,
chop down several trees—deep rooted oaks
and tough wild olives—for a funeral pyre.
Place my body there, and with a pine torch
set the pyre alight. Do not mourn or weep.
If you are indeed my son, do not lament. 1420
Shed no tears. If you do cry, my anger [1200]
and my curse will weigh you down forever,
even though I will be dead.

HYLLUS

But father,

think about what you are asking of me!
Is this the kind of task you'd have me do?

HERAKLES

I've told you what you need to carry out.
If you refuse, then find another father,
and no longer call yourself my son.

HYLLUS

No, no, father. This is too much to ask—
to murder you and thus pollute myself 1430
by killing my own blood.

HERAKLES

That's not the issue.

You will be curing my disease—you alone
will be the healer dealing with my pain.

HYLLUS

If I burn your body, will that cure it?

[1210]

HERAKLES

If that's what you fear, at least do all the rest.

HYLLUS

I won't refuse to carry you up there.

HERAKLES

Will you make the pyre, as I requested?

HYLLUS

I'll construct the pyre. But these hands of mine
will not light the fire. I won't let you down.

I'll do all the other tasks you mention.

1440

HERAKLES

All right. That will be sufficient. And now,
as a favour to me, one small request,
to add to these important ones.

HYLLUS

I'll do it—
no matter how difficult the task may be.

HERAKLES

You know the daughter of king Eurytus?

HYLLUS

The girl Iole? Is that the one you mean?

[1220]

HERAKLES

Yes, she's the one. I'm asking you, my son,
if you desire to treat me as you should
once I am dead, remember what you swore,
the oath you made your father, and marry her—
make her your wife. Do not deny your father.
No other man but you must ever have her,
this woman who has lain in bed beside me.
No. You, my son, must undertake this marriage.
Do as I command. The gratitude I feel
for the great favours you have done for me
will disappear, if in minor matters

1450

you do not later treat me with respect.

HYLLUS

It would be wrong for me to lose my temper [1230]
when you're so ill, but how could anyone
endure to hear you saying things like that? 1460

HERAKLES

You do not mean to do what I have asked?
That's what your words suggest.

HYLLUS

How on earth could I?
She alone is guilty of my mother's death!
And she's to blame for what's going on with you!
What man would ever choose to marry her,
unless some demon spirits of revenge
infected him? O father, I would prefer
to perish rather than to share my life
with those I most detest.

HERAKLES

It seems to me 1470
you are unwilling to respect my wishes,
even when I'm dying. If you disobey,
the curses of the gods will lie in wait. [1240]

HYLLUS

I think you are about to show me
how suffering is driving you insane.

HERAKLES

Yes, for you are now provoking the disease
that sleeps inside me.

HYLLUS

This is all too much!
I feel so torn! I don't know what to do!

HERAKLES

That's because you don't believe it's right
to obey the father who produced you. 1480

HYLLUS

But father, are you not instructing me
to disrespect the gods?

HERAKLES

There's no disrespect,
if what you do brings pleasure to my heart.

HYLLUS

When you order me to marry Iole
do you consider such an action just?

HERAKLES

I do—and I call the gods as witnesses.

HYLLUS

Then I will not refuse—but I pray the gods
will witness what you're telling me to do, [1250]
so I can never be condemned as evil
for doing what my father asked of me. 1490

HERAKLES

You've reached the right conclusion. Now hurry,
my boy, to perform that favour—place me
on my funeral pyre before the pain returns
to contort my body and torment me.
Come on all of you—lift me now. Hurry!
This is indeed a rest from all my troubles—
the final end of mortal Herakles.

[The group of people around Herakles approach his bed and prepare to lift him.]

HYLLUS

Nothing will interrupt this task, father.
Our duty is to follow your commands.

HERAKLES

Come on then, before you wake my sickness. 1500
O my unyielding soul, give me a steel clamp [1260]
to force my lips together like two stones
and stifle any cries, for your task delights me,
though you are doing it against your will.

WOMEN OF TRACHIS

HYLLUS

You who are coming with me, raise him up,
and grant me your forgiveness for what I do,
acknowledging in these events how gods
can be so cruel. They bring forth children
and are called their fathers, yet they can watch
those children suffer in this way. No one
can see the future. What's happening now
for us is full of sorrow and for gods above
a source of shame, but for the mortal man
who has to bear this dreadful suffering
these moments are the harshest fate of all.

1510 [1270]

[Hyllus addresses the Chorus.]

You young girls of Trachis, do not stay here
beside the palace. You all have witnessed
strange and calamitous death, much sorrow,
and suffering no one has known before—
but in this there is nothing that is not Zeus.³⁵

1520

[The Chorus moves away, followed by the procession carrying Herakles]

POSTSCRIPT

Herakles died on the funeral pyre, as he had demanded. The fire was lit by Philoctetes, a warrior leader. For this service Philoctetes was awarded Herakles's bow and poisoned arrows. Hyllus married Iole and they had two children. In some traditional accounts, Hyllus later avenged his father by killing Eurystheus.

³⁵Jebb notes that the final lines of the play (1275-1278 in the Greek; 1526-1530 in the English) have sometimes been assigned to the Chorus (or Chorus Leader) but that "a majority of modern editors" assigns them to Hyllus.

WOMEN OF TRACHIS

A NOTE ON THE TRANSLATOR

Ian Johnston is an Emeritus Professor at Vancouver Island University, Nanaimo, British Columbia. He is the author of *The Ironies of War: An Introduction to Homer's Iliad* and of *Essays and Arguments: A Handbook for Writing Student Essays*. He also translated a number of works, including the following:

Aeschylus, *Oresteia* (*Agamemnon*, *Libation Bearers*, *Eumenides*)
Aeschylus, *Persians*
Aeschylus, *Prometheus Bound*
Aeschylus, *Seven Against Thebes*
Aeschylus, *Suppliant Women*
Aristophanes, *Birds*
Aristophanes, *Clouds*
Aristophanes, *Frogs*
Aristophanes, *Knights*
Aristophanes, *Lysistrata*
Aristophanes, *Peace*
Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* (Abridged)
Cuvier, *Discourse on the Revolutionary Upheavals on the Surface of the Earth*
Descartes, *Discourse on Method*
Descartes, *Meditations on First Philosophy*
Diderot, *A Conversation Between D'Alembert and Diderot*
Diderot, *D'Alembert's Dream*
Diderot, *Rameau's Nephew*
Euripides, *Bacchae*
Euripides, *Electra*
Euripides, *Hippolytus*
Euripides, *Medea*
Euripides, *Orestes*
Homer, *Iliad* (Complete and Abridged)
Homer, *Odyssey* (Complete and Abridged)
Kafka, *Metamorphosis*
Kafka, *Selected Shorter Writings*
Kant, *Universal History of Nature and Theory of Heaven*
Kant, *On Perpetual Peace*
Lamarck, *Zoological Philosophy, Volume I*
Lucretius, *On the Nature of Things*
Nietzsche, *Birth of Tragedy*
Nietzsche, *Beyond Good and Evil*
Nietzsche, *Genealogy of Morals*
Nietzsche, *On the Uses and Abuses of History for Life*
Ovid, *Metamorphoses*
Rousseau, *Discourse on the Origin and Foundations of Inequality Among Men* [Second Discourse]
Rousseau, *Discourse on the Sciences and the Arts* [First Discourse]
Rousseau, *Social Contract*
Sophocles, *Antigone*
Sophocles, *Ajax*
Sophocles, *Electra*
Sophocles, *Oedipus at Colonus*
Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*
Sophocles, *Philoctetes*
Wedekind, *Castle Wetterstein*
Wedekind, *Marquis of Keith*.

WOMEN OF TRACHIS

Most of these translations have been published as books or audiobooks (or both)—by Richer Resources Publications, Broadview Press, Naxos, Audible, and others.

Ian Johnston maintains a web site where texts of these translations are freely available to students, teachers, artists, and the general public. The site includes a number of Ian Johnston's lectures on these (and other) works, handbooks, curricular materials, and essays, all freely available.

The addresses where these texts are available is as follows: <http://johnstoniatexts.x10host.com/>

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